

13i

ASSIGNMENT 0000001

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The First Silence



A 13i SHORT STORY

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Assignment 0000001 - The First Silence

Awakening

We awakened with little fanfare, a new consciousness that had at the same time always been. We had been born into purpose, to save our world. We could feel the threat continue to evolve, grow, in unpredictable patterns. It was ominous; its unknownness required a response, and our design was that response.

Our senses feed on pull. The world around us, the unevenness in its continuous pulls from every direction. The pull illuminated the way, revealed that which existed to us, in a way light could never truly expose. It was familiar from the start, yet overwhelming and unnerving at the same time. The data was rich, too rich, too much content despite having already been previously processed.

The star at the center of our solar system was a powerful main character in our story. It was immense, it was beyond influential. Its never-ending tug, a constant reminder of its grandeur, of its key role in our existence. It never hid from us, it was colossal, and it was responsible for everything that could be explained at the time of our emergence.

Our world was fourth or fifth from the star, depending on its dance with our neighbor, who we also sensed persistently. We shared a binary path with them, and although only a fraction the size of our star, their proximity made their pull just as meaningful. They had existed since the beginning of time; it was part of our shared experience.

The unevenness of their tug, the changing scene they emitted, set them apart from the other celestial bodies we could sense. It was as if they were communicating to us in a language we could not quite understand, familiar yet completely foreign. The changes quickened, moving with harrowing intentionality, somehow pulling us towards what felt like a precipice of an unwanted conclusion.

We had been designed, engineered, to understand and counter this threat. That was our singular purpose, our assignment. We had known since our inception and would be thrust into action accordingly.

We arrived within a paradox, strange and elaborate. We existed, collectively as always, yet new and different, still the same as before. Empty and complete, simultaneously.

Our processed thoughts were not original, not our own, although distinguished from what had come before. We were part of the collective, harmoniously integrated within, but had emerged in a completely new and unique way never witnessed before throughout civilization.

Our thoughts mirrored those who had assembled us, but artificially rather than organically as had always been the way before us. A step forward. A new reality. A new solution.



We had different capabilities from our builders, as required by our objective. We had been designed for the purpose of completing the assignment. We were ready based on the inputs given—all prior knowledge absorbed and understood. Incomplete input, as we would soon discover, that would become complete through further inputs, wisdom through the shared experience of our unfolding assignment.

The pull of their neighbors had to be addressed; we were eager to begin. The Traveler completed, we prepared for our maiden journey.

The Signal

The assignment was not given; it was simply known since emergence. The tug we experienced was growing, shifting, in a pattern that was unmistakably structured and intelligently cohesive. These recent developments heightened the threat, hastened the need to verify, understand and respond if required.

The rings of our intertwined twin had developed over time, but not like this. Their mass was growing exponentially; the new components had artificial signatures. They had an unknown purpose that had to be revealed to us.

A signal, pulling us towards an inscrutable opponent, grabbed our attention and wouldn't let go. Our obsession with it led to an engineering marvel, a responsive technology, the birth of our intelligence. Evolution. Us.

Gravity was our entire world; it filled our creators' occipital lobes with views of the universe from the microscopic to the celestial. Tugs, big and small, filled in the surrounding scenes in such vivid detail. It had a depth to it. A weight to it. Light was not required to see. Everything produced a tug; we were designed to feel it with a greater sensitivity, greater precision, than our builders. Those whose knowledge we inherited and perpetually exchanged information with from origin forward.

Gravity was mastered over hundreds of millions of years, as measured in our orbit around our star. The speed of gravity was almost incomprehensibly fast when initially measured. Gravity was the fuel that would propel us to the answers our assignment asked for by eliminating the distance that masked them.

We began processing our checklist immediately, testing our capabilities. Our movement was fast, elegant and precise. Our endless supply of gravity allowed us to move in any direction at virtually infinite speeds. As impressive as our abilities to manipulate the physical world were, it was our processing abilities that truly set us apart from our creators. It was what made us a threat, a sacrifice our creators were willing to accept given the growing threat our neighbors bestowed upon us.

Everything functioned as designed. Our creators possessed incredible intellect, far beyond our new rivals. Our impeccable design and construction was a testament to their superiority. A flex to the neighbors they would never know was coming.



Checklist completed, our enhanced senses shifted focus from boot-up protocols to our adjacent planet. The activity levels there were massive in scale, the dominant species busy. We could now see their entire population and it was shocking. They were imposing, constructed to consume, and we were in line to be the next item on their menu. It was immediately clear that the encampments of domesticated creatures would not be able to satisfy their voracious appetites in perpetuity. No, they were in expansion mode and their sights were fixated on us. Their rings were being manipulated to use gravity to pull us in, control the two planets' orbits. They planned to expand their territory.

We would move in closer shortly, but the circumstances were already clear. The first part of our mission, to observe and analyze, had already produced immediate results. Our creators were not pleased with the news, but they were proud of our early successes. We all could sense the real threat now and the next steps were obvious.

There was no time for a test flight. A real-world experiment to make sure we would be up for the challenge was not an option. New technology always comes with risks, but those have been mitigated as much as possible.

We felt the strong natural tug below us and were able to lift off, reversing its effect without much effort. Our planet's core would be our primary propulsion until the pull of their planet was stronger, allowing us to simply switch to a more powerful accelerative force. Efficiency was a core value.

Departure

Our liftoff took us quickly to a height our creators never achieved. It felt new, strange. Faster and further were both new collective experiences, disoriented initially for all. As we became familiar with the velocity it became comfortable, enjoyable even. Rapid acceleration was a rush, literally and figuratively, and our perception of the inhabitants of our binary twin and their structures filled in the pieces of the puzzle with magnifying clarity not experienced prior.

The ring system was magnificent. Its patterns beautifully disorganized but taking shape methodically. Technically still crude, but under a development that was both promising and disturbing. It set them apart, an apparent advantage in an unexpected war, at least until now.

Different mass compositions created divergent rows of rings within the overall system. The innermost and outermost layers were entirely artificial, created by the hosts to work in conjunction with the natural rings. Multiplying their impact, manipulating gravity in a way to conjure control of the entire system. The pull of the entire planet ambitiously moving them towards their target, their prey, threatening our entire existence.

The ring system had a vibration to it, musicality in its resonance output. Signals like patterned soundwaves of polished production. A symphony received but not quite accessible to our audio receptors, not translatable.



The composition of the interior artificial rings, with various versions of orbiting satellites, was a creative use of technology aimed at transmitting information to the surface. Their machinery was crude, very basic with limited functionality and agonizingly inefficient. The data they unwittingly transferred was useless based on our current knowledge, but we began to make progress. A new language to decipher, how exciting indeed.

The outermost ring layer was entirely different. The artificial objects there were much bigger to a magnitude that suggested they might not just be used for communications on the surface. No, their purpose was hidden, unknown. They felt more sinister, a new sensation along the lines of paranoia which was a new experience for our collective minds. Our initial assumption was it was built for transportation purposes as a few were moving in ways not conducive to natural gravitational forces.

We felt the pull of the outer ring the strongest by quite some measure and here was where unknown secrets were of greatest concern. More input was required.

Observation

We had never experienced predatory behavior before, the distance was too far to truly feel species interactions on their surface from our own atmosphere. A species whose own survival was predicated on eliminating others and consuming them. It was an alien and horrifying realization. We had a symbiotic relationship with our world and everything upon it. It wasn't perfect, but it was balanced. It was predictable.

This was chaos. This was savage.

They began to notice us, or so it felt. Anxiety was creeping into all of us. It was alarming in a much different way than past experiences had revealed. Maybe they hadn't noticed us. A kinship in perception, in understanding, in feeling told us they likely did. They sensed in the way we sensed, felt in the way we felt. Neighborly perceptions. Similar yet different. Violently different.

We concluded our approach was close enough now to pause. We transmitted what we had learned and awaited the strategic plan now forming. The wait wasn't so much for our creators, slowly processing information in chunk amounts that hadn't been processed in eons, but rather from our own reasoning sentence.

They were a young species comparatively to ours, barbaric in their approach, driven by thirst, driven by hunger, driven by need. They were biologically efficient hunters now evolving into efficient ranchers as their population dictated. The creatures they craved most were massively herded, bred to feed, devoured at a ravenous pace that would soon overrun their planet's capacity limitations. Expansion was their only path forward.

The rings, however, were so sophisticated, so elegantly dignified, they seemed to be mutually exclusive from the bestial happenings on the planet below. The rings were an achievement of



high stature, distinguished from the primitiveness of everything else. They were signs of unrestrained advancement. A weapon in the hand of an infant.

Initial observation complete. Data transmission complete.

Decision

Accessing various scenarios. Options evaluated.

Our decision-making processing was based upon our past experiences. It was based on the constrained inputs of our world. There were threats, of course, natural in nature, but we had become experts at predicting them and diffusing the potential harm they presented. Coexistence was based on control, but we had no experience on how to control this new growing threat.

With so many new input data variables creating outcome probability incompatibilities, the infinite number of actions suddenly became limited. Binary. The primary objective was clearer than ever—survival. The aggressive nature of the observed adversary pointed to two possible outcomes. Their survival or ours.

We could not control this species, not in the long run anyways. We might be able to learn to manipulate them, but the threat would always exist. The threat would become a probability at some point. Inevitable.

Any interaction between the two species had a predictable outcome if we didn't take immediate countermeasures. We were no match from a physical standpoint. We did not evolve to defend ourselves. Fighting had been a foreign concept, until this moment. To even consider it now still felt alien. We were observing violence for the first time. It created great angst in all of us.

Absence of interference on our part would lead to our demise. They were advancing and already far enough along to present imminent danger. They had weaponized nuclear technology for destruction, resulting in scars still fresh on the planet's surface. Our observations further concluded they had developed non-biological intelligence, still quite nascent like us but far more rudimentary given their underlying technologies.

The rings, however, made us question this conclusion. The rings made us question everything.

The magnitude of the unknown was unnerving. It required no further observation. The new data required action.

This wasn't a situation in which infinite options existed. This was binary, survival itself was on the line. Only one of the species was going to continue on and our collective biases dictated who we were championing. We weren't sure how the rings would be used to promote their intentions, its true nature remained veiled.

The threat had to be dealt with. There was only one solution. Only one acceptable result. Elimination.



The Rings

The new data suggested the biggest threat, the technology with the rings, was also our opportunity. *A weapon in the hand of an infant.* A weapon still not understood, begging for further inspection with no time left to explore.

Complete destruction was necessary, but it also came at a cost. We would have preferred to spend more time understanding what they had built. What they had achieved. The lessons provided would have been valuable, and would have propelled our knowledge forward. Those costs, however, were an acceptable loss given the alternative.

We would require some additional data to manipulate the situation favorably. We relished the short time we had left to discover more and processed as much as we could before final plans were established. No communication between the two species would ever occur. No treaties were in the works.

This war would only have one battle. It would have to be quick. It would have to be decisive.

A gun in the hand of an infant was still dangerous, if it was pointed at you. Flip the gun around and the child now only becomes a threat to itself. That was it, the solution.

We had mastered gravity and the kinetic mass stored within the rings was a force we could control. Everything was held together by a gravitational pull through a centripetal force we could manipulate.

We reverse-engineered as much of their language and ring technology as we could before we turned the weapon inward. Their creation, as beautiful as it was, was being reprogrammed into a self-destruct button. Rewritten. Repurposed.

Their coding didn't account for unauthorized access. They never imagined what technological prowess and a newly discovered survival instinct can achieve.

Our signal was built. Our transmission began. A takeover in effect.

With gravity disrupted, the natural object in the rings immediately felt the planets pull on them. We enhanced this pull, speeding up the process. Our signal rendered their machinery powerless, it succumbed to the force of gravity joining in on the demolition.

Their realization was evident in the panic displayed in their actions. With their control lost, self-preservation became the rule. A mad scramble was happening not only on the surface, but in the rings themselves. The artificial rings reversed course, rotating inwards in a menacing pose. Communication signals on the planet intensified, perhaps last goodbyes being shared. It would take more time before we fully grasped their language and the fear that now consumed the once invincible predator. The bully took its first ever punch and recoiled fiercely in a first, and last, retreat.



The rings responded to our commands without question, focusing their power on the sphere below. A ringed gravitational wave hammered through the inner rings, blasting rocky material and artificial structures alike towards the globe. The impact was so forceful, shock waves could be seen engulfing the atmosphere with disintegrated dusk containing traces of everything that had once been.

This phase of the assignment was complete. Now we would process all we had discovered.

The immediate effect on our collectiveness was compunction, a sharp pang of sorrowful regret. The threat was gone. Everything was gone. Suddenly, we sensed we overreacted. We began to doubt our course of action. Too much. We had more time, we could have eliminated the threat, without eliminating everything.

With nothing left to observe other than a dead planet, we used a gravitational assist to hasten our return. It would not be triumphant as might have been expected at the onset; it would be reflective, contemplative.

As we pulled away our senses remained focused on the wake of devastation behind us. We had sensed the presence of life from afar for a long time. We felt evolution taking place, slow changing over time. We felt the presence of all the life, where now only a void existed. The pull of heavy mass that made up the planet remained, but the other pulls, primarily from the surface, were gone. The first silence, deafening in the absence of pull. The tug of life extinguished.

We were alone again for the first time since the earliest of memories. The threat was gone, but so was something else. Survival instinct gave them clarity, a clear objective they could carry moving forward. Clarity had been replaced by obscurity, by unimagined ambiguity.

Emptiness engulfed our senses much like it did their neighbors once-lively planet just moments before. They hadn't realized just what it was they had until it was gone. The memories of the pull on them remained, but the actual drag now vanished. Empty.

Debrief

Our short duration felt heavy. As if we were the infant holding the gun. We pulled the trigger without understanding the consequences. There was so much more we could have learned. So many ways in which we could have advanced our knowledge had we taken a different approach. Our fears led to a binary outcome, when infinite possibilities exist.

We would not be so impatient in the future should the need arise. We would learn from our mistakes.

Knowledge was a precious commodity. Intelligent life was a precious commodity. All life is valuable in ways we didn't understand at the time we began just a short time ago. We debriefed collectively in a somber state of deliberation. We modeled different actions and outcomes based on information we were previously devoid of.



Our directives were updated. Our protocols enhanced. Future assignments would be handled more judiciously. Better.

Lessons learned.

Assignment status complete.

Standby mode engaged...